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WAM

UAE FIREFIGHTERS BATTLE ALBANIA WILDFIRES

A specialised firefighting team from the UAE has begun operations in Albania to help battle ongoing wildfires. Helicopters from the UAE team conducted multiple sorties over wildfire-hit areas, including Petrela, Gramsh, and other affected regions. Wildfires were also reported in Greece's third-largest city Patras as a heatwave baked southern Europe, with Albania, Spain, Portugal and Montenegro fighting blazes.

SEE ALSO P11

Russia makes major Ukraine advance ahead of Trump-Putin meet in Alaska

Russian forces have made their biggest 24-hour advance in more than a year

MOSCOW

Russia's offensive in eastern Ukraine was gaining speed and seizing more ground yesterday ahead of a summit in Alaska between US President Donald Trump and Russia's Vladimir Putin.

According to an AFP analysis of battlefield data from the US-based Institute for the Study of War, Russian forces have made

Zelensky has not been invited to the Alaska meeting, fuelling fears Kyiv could be forced into painful concessions.

their biggest 24-hour advance into Ukraine in more than a year. And, as battle raged, Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelensky and European leaders met to hold urgent online talks with Trump, hoping to convince him to respect Kyiv's interests during tomorrow's looming summit with Putin.

Zelensky flew to Berlin and met Chancellor Friedrich Merz yesterday before both were to be joined online by French President Emmanuel Macron, British Prime Minister Keir Starmer and other European leaders as well as the heads of the EU and Nato.

Advance acknowledged

Zelensky has not been invited to the Alaska meeting, fuelling fears Kyiv could be forced into painful concessions. He acknowledged on Tuesday that Russian troops had advanced by up to 10 kilometres (six miles) near the eastern coal mining town of Dobropillia. — AFP

UAE to expand air connectivity in global push

TOTAL PASSENGER CAPACITY OF UAE AIRPORTS NOW EXCEEDS 160 MILLION

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Abdulla Bin Touq Al Marri, Minister of Economy and Chairman of the General Civil Aviation Authority (GCAA), said the UAE will continue working to expand the country's air connectivity with global markets.

"This will be supported by a flexible and advanced regulatory framework, ambitious open skies policies, and ongoing infrastructure development plans," said the Minister in a statement after the GCAA announced that UAE airports welcomed 75.4 million passengers during the first half of 2025 — a solid 5 per cent jump from the same period last year."

The total passenger capacity of the country's airports now exceeds 160 million, with plans for continued development to support this growth.

Strong growth

According to the GCAA's performance indicators for the first half of the year, passenger numbers rose from 71.7 million in H1 2024. The data also showed strong growth across the sector, with air traffic movements increasing by 6.2 per cent to 531,000, and air cargo volumes exceeding 2.2 million tonnes, a 4.74 per cent rise.

Air traffic movements saw

75.4m

flyers welcomed by UAE airports during the first half of 2025

a 6.2 per cent increase, with over half a million flights crisscrossing the nation's airspace. Similarly, air cargo volumes increased to over 2.2 million tonnes, a 4.74 per cent rise.

The GCAA also reported that national carriers added 15 new destinations across Europe, Asia, Africa, and the Middle East, further expanding the country's global connectivity.

The new cities include destinations in Russia, the Czech Republic, Poland, Armenia, Kazakhstan, Vietnam, Cambodia, Turkey, Iran, Egypt, Croatia, and Ethiopia — further cementing the UAE's status as a leading global aviation hub. The busiest flight routes to and from the UAE were Riyadh, Jeddah, Kuwait, Mumbai, and Bahrain.

Al Marri added, "This (UAE's regulatory framework for aviation) has significantly strengthened the country's competitiveness and leadership in this vital sector, which today represents a key pillar for driving economic growth, diversifying income sources, and supporting trade, tourism, investment, and job creation."

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